# Simple play ideas, led by your child

Document: PAR-KB-07 | Version: 1.0 | Prepared: 24 October 2026

Scope: Optional, non-clinical play ideas for babies and young children through age five. The age groups help navigation; they are not milestone expectations or a test of readiness.

## How do I choose a play idea?

Choose something your child already seems comfortable exploring. Stay with them, keep the activity brief if they prefer, and stop or change it when they lose interest or seem uncomfortable. There is no need to finish a game or achieve a learning target.

For toy-based play, follow the manufacturer's age and safety guidance and choose objects that suit the child's abilities. Keep small parts, small balls and loose packaging out of reach, especially for children under three. These safety principles draw on CPSC guidance. [S6] Supervision does not make an unsuitable object safe.

## What can I try with a baby under one?

Use face, voice and shared attention; no special equipment is needed. Try gently copying a sound or expression your baby makes, then pause. If they respond, take another turn. If they look away or fuss, let the game end. This is an adaptation of UNICEF's imitation idea and Harvard's responsive interaction guidance, not an age-based skill requirement. [S7, S1]

You can also name something your baby is already looking at. Keep the interaction unhurried. This is shared attention, not a test of vision, hearing or development. [S1]

## What can I try with a toddler, roughly one to three?

Try a copying game. Let your child choose a simple action they already do comfortably, such as waving or clapping, and copy them. Invite another turn without insisting. You can join their play by describing one action, such as "You moved it over here," rather than asking constant questions. These examples adapt UNICEF's imitation play and CDC's guidance on describing a child's actions. [S7, S3]

For a quiet alternative, choose a favourite picture book and look at one page together. Follow what catches their attention; a short shared look is fine. The emphasis is enjoyment, not reciting words correctly. [S8]

## What can I try with a preschool child, roughly three to five?

Open a familiar picture book and invite your child to choose a picture to talk about. They might describe it, make a sound or simply listen. Avoid turning it into a quiz or pushing them to read words before they want to. AAP guidance encourages enjoyable books and learning at the child's pace. [S8]

For an original no-equipment idea, pretend you are both choosing a name for an imaginary pet. Take turns offering a name, sound or gesture. Let your child change the story or stop whenever they want. This is a creative prompt, not a developmental exercise or an evidence-tested programme.

## What if we have little space, energy or equipment?

Choose one quiet option: a sound-copying turn, looking at a book already available, or an imaginary-pet story. All can happen without buying an activity kit. Adapt the pace, position and communication style to what is comfortable for your child. There is no need to compare their response with another child's.

If an activity needs adaptations beyond what you know is comfortable, ask a qualified professional who knows your child. These ideas do not replace an individual support plan.

## What can I tell Ask Parvarish to get a useful suggestion?

Try: "Suggest one quiet indoor game for a child around two who likes animal sounds. No materials." A broad age, an interest and a practical constraint are enough. A name, exact birth date or medical record is not needed. Chat suggestions are text ideas; they are not saved to a personalised activity feed.

## Sources and further reading

[S1] Harvard Center on the Developing Child: 5 Steps for Brain-Building Serve and Return. Supports responding to the child's interest and leaving time for a reply.

https://developingchild.harvard.edu/resources/briefs/5-steps-for-brain-building-serve-and-return/

[S3] CDC: Tips for Connecting and Communicating. Supports imitation and describing play.

https://www.cdc.gov/parenting-toddlers/communication/index.html

[S6] US Consumer Product Safety Commission: Toys. Supports matching toys to abilities, age labels and avoiding small parts and packaging.

https://www.cpsc.gov/Safety-Education/Safety-Education-Centers/Toys

[S7] UNICEF: 21 learning activities for babies and toddlers. Used for the imitation-play principle only, without adopting milestone targets or all activities in that article.

https://www.unicef.org/parenting/child-care/21-learning-activities-babies-and-toddlers

[S8] American Academy of Pediatrics / HealthyChildren.org: Is Your Child Ready to Read? Supports child-led enjoyment of books without pressure to read early.

https://www.healthychildren.org/English/ages-stages/preschool/Pages/Is-Your-Child-Ready-to-Read.aspx

No endorsement by these organisations is implied. Related: PAR-KB-06 for everyday connection.